Chapter 11: Walk in the Garden. Find Thieves.

Teams didn't want to have to travel home after a long day of battles, so they were allowed to stay at the Team complex in their wings.

Terrian went to the restaurant to eat. Each wing housed a different group, but in the middle was a shared restaurant and gym… Well, shared by everyone but Aschelle. They had their own dining area which was much nicer and their own gym. They always seemed to get perks because the head of the counsel always was from Aschelle. York was too.

Catria stepped into the dining hall and looked around.

"He's not here yet," Hrod teased her.

"Who?" Catria asked, knowing full well what he meant.

"You have it so bad," Hrod teased.

They served themselves food and sat down with the team. Rhys was talking to the others, concerned that

Catria had drawn too much attention to herself.

She was very worried and listening intently until the Cruian team came in.

“Over here,” Hrod called to them. He then nudged Catria. “See, I have your back.”

Team Cruia got their food and came over.

Hrod moved and offered his seat to Erik.

Catria blushed slightly and asked, “Is your team mad at me because I healed Slayde before your fight.”

“No way,” Erik laughed. “Honestly, I thought the Phyrnians would be harder to fight.”

“They aren’t easy,” Rhys countered. “You guys are just good.”

“I’ve never seen anything like what you did today,” Sean added. “First, you guys are strong. Second, I have never seen anything like what you did, Erik. That was incredible. Did you get that because you have unicorn?”

“I assume,” Erik answered. “It’s strong magic.”

“I can’t do that,” Catria noted. “I just heal.”

“Just heal,” Erik exclaimed. “What you do is amazing! Rhys would have died if you didn’t heal him today.”

Hrod chuckled, “Just think what the two of you could do together, Erik. With Catria’s healing and your invisible force fields, you two could beat anyone.

Erik smiled. “Catria’s more than a healer. I did some

work with her with her staff. She's an amazing fighter."

"I'm glad I didn't have to fight today," Catria admitted. "The battles were tough."

"Not for them" Sean joked, pointing to the Cruian boys. "You guys are tough. How many hours a day do you train?"

"Generally two," Dillion answered to Terrian's shock. Dillion explained, "In Cruia, we all work hard. We chop wood, take care of the farm, and do some pretty heavy lifting. As war mages, we do a lot of the hard work. That keeps us in shape. And honestly, Slayde just doesn't seem too tough compared to an angry bull. None of the Phyrnians do."

"Maybe we should visit Cruia and learn from you," Rhys suggested.

"I'd love to visit Cruia," Catria admitted.

Hrod laughed. "Erik, I think that means she wants to visit you. Ask her if you can call on her. She wants you to."

Erik turned a bit red but suggested to Catria, "We'll talk after the meal. Would you like to go on a walk?"

"It's not safe," Rhys countered. "If we go anywhere, it needs to be as a team."

"How romantic," Hrod snipped. "They will be fine. Erik could have fought the entire Phyrnian team, and he's right that Catria is tough. Let them have some privacy."

"Privacy in our wing, sure," Rhys suggested.

“Outside, it’s not safe.”

Hrod leaned over and whispered, “Catria really has fallen for him. Give her a chance with him.”

“Fine,” Rhys conceded. “I guess they are pretty tough.”

“A real power duo,” Sean chimed in.

There was more teasing and talk of the battles. Everyone seemed concerned about York. He hit all of them wrong.

Catria didn’t worry too much about all of it, as she was just eager to finish eating and get to go walking with Erik.

They had a nice conversation while they ate, but as soon as they were done, Erik leaned over and whispered, “Do you want to go out on that walk?”

Did she want to go? Of course she wanted to go. There was some playful teasing of the two as they left, but neither minded.

When they stepped out, Erik offered her his arm and suggested, “Let’s go walk around the garden.”

There was a pretty large garden by the complex because the cooks at the complex did need a great deal of food for everyone on battle days.

They walked through the rows of vegetables and through through a field of fruit trees. As they walked, Catria asked, “What’s life in Cruia like?”

“We’re mostly farmers,” Erik answered. “Of course we have blacksmiths and coopers and every other type of needed profession too, but Cruia isn’t like Ramere with their big factories or like Murash with their boats and fishing. We are all just down to earth people who work hard to make life nice.”

“That’s a great deal how Terrian is too,” Catria noted. “We are structured differently. We don’t have serfs or slaves like Aschelle, but we do have a king and each war mage has a province he’s over.”

“We have a sheriff,” Erik explained. “He is to keep the peace and punish any lawbreakers. There really aren’t many.”

“Terrian is pretty peaceful too.” Catria smiled. “I’d like to visit Cruia.”

“You’d like it there,” Erik assured her. “Honestly, I like it in Terrian.” He took her hand and looked in her eyes. “At least I really like a beautiful lady there.”

Catria blushed and suggested, “I know a Terrian maiden who still owes you a hero’s kiss. After all, you did save my life.”

Erik didn’t say anything back. He put his arms around her waist, pulled her in closer to him, and leaned in close.

She gladly gave him his hero’s kiss. As she did, her heart pounded and shivers of excitement ran through her. She wasn’t sure if the flutter she felt was coming from her or butterflies around.

After the kiss, she threw her arms around him, hugged him tightly, and laid her head on his shoulder.

The two stayed embraced with him gently rubbing his hand along her back.

Catria knew, even though they hadn't known each other long that he was the man of her dreams, the man she wanted to be with forever.

Erik surprised her as he leaned back some, gently moved some hair that was falling over her eyes, and confessed, "Catria, I love you. It may sound odd, but I've felt this way since I met you on the soul quest. I want to be your suitor and see if this is what I think it is." He smiled with a sparkle in his eyes. "I think it is."

"I do too," Catria admitted. "Perhaps you could stop by Terrian on the way to Cruia and see my province. I don't run it. My father does. He was injured in the arena, but he can run the province well."

"I'd like that," Erik accepted. "After that, maybe I can take you to Cruia and let you see my life. I don't have a province there, but I do have cattle and a coppersmith shop.

"You do copper work?" Catria asked. "You never told me that."

He shrugged. "You never asked. My main job is cattle, and now that I'm a war mage, I'm going to give my copper shop to my brother. He's good."

She excitedly threw her arms around him, exclaiming,

“I’d love to see it!”

He hugged her and spun her around.

When he put her down, he looked into her eyes again. The connection between them made them glow, literally.

“Odd,” Catria noted. “I didn’t know either of us glowed.”

“It’s likely the unicorn,” Erik suggested. “With both of us having unicorn, that likely strengthens it.”

Catria smiled. “I guess we would make a good team.”

“Oh yes,” Erik agreed. “If things go as I think they will, we’ll make more than a good team.”

Catria’s eyes went wide. Was he really suggesting what she thought? Again, a glow came to her face.

He held out his hand, and she took it. They walked hand in hand back toward the entrance of the complex.

As they walked, they heard the rustling of leaves and whispers on the wind.

Erik didn’t say a word, but he pulled Catria behind a tree. Then he leaned around to listen.

There were two voices, both male. The first was very gruff. “Do you have the goods?”

“I do,” the other voice answered. The voice had an odd sound to it, a bit of a laugh like a hyena. That likely meant the man was Faeborn. “Do you have the money?”

“I do,” the low voice answered. “I’ll have even more if you can plant this in Terrian or Cruia.”

“Did you see their magic today?” the Faeborn voice replied. “To plant something in Cruia will cost extra. Their captain controlled his knives with song. He didn’t have to touch them. The one with the whip could put up invisible shields.”

“Then frame Terrian,” the low voice instructed. “But we do need to find a way to get Xena from Cruia. The money for her return is good.”

“I’ll see what I can do,” the Faeborn replied. “Perhaps I could send a grogosh in to find her. Then we can plan a rescue.”

The man with the low voice laughed. “Yes, rescue.”

Erik knew he wasn’t to draw blood outside the arena, but he couldn’t let the men get away with their crime, so he stepped from behind the tree and called for them to stop. Definitely one of the men was Faeborn. The other was Phyrnian, but Erik wasn’t familiar enough with the tribes to identify which one the man was from from his appearance.

Both of the men attacked, but Erik pushed them back with an invisible shield and Catria stepped from behind the tree.

Seeing they were up against two war mages, both of the men ran. The Faeborn moved so quickly that Erik wasn’t sure where he went, but Erik was able to tackle the Phyrnian.

Catria came over to help subdue him.

It didn’t take them long to get him in the complex and to the Terrian wing. Dillion was fetched, and Rhys and Dillion both saw to it that the man was turned over to the counsel. After all, the complex was not in any city, so the counsel had jurisdiction over any crimes.

York was brought in, as was Councilman Noah because the stolen item was a part from a Ramere factory. Obviously, an act of sabotage.

York had the prisoner questioned, but the man refused to answer.

“We’ll get him to,” York assured the others. “This is a reason for the lesser war mages. Now, everyone is dismissed. The part will be returned to Terrian and appropriate punishment will be given.”

Appropriate punishment. What exactly did York mean by that?

Erik didn’t really care, as he was much more interested in spending time with Catria. Yet, he helped as needed.

When they were finished, both teams Terrian and Cruia met together to discuss what happened.

Rhys was very concerned, noting, “Erik, you have put an even bigger target on your back. I fear you have Catria’s too.”

“I’ll protect her,” Erik offered. “I don’t mind living in Terrian for a while to watch her, if you’ll let me work out with the team and bring my cattle up, so I can tend to

them. Is there a place I could keep them?"

"Of course," Catria assured him. "Remember that each war mage is over a province. We have resources."

Erik turned to Dillion. "Can I stay here for a while to make sure Catria's safe."

Dillion laughed. "You can stay here. I doubt it will just be for a while. Everyone knows you and Catria will end up getting married."

Erik froze I place, his eyes wide.

Henry smacked him on his shoulder. "Oh, we all see it coming. Do you realize that your eyes literally glow at times when you look at her?"

That was embarrassing. He looked down as he answered, "No."

There was some playful teasing, but Rhys pulled them back to the issue at hand, insisting, "We have a problem to deal with. Obviously, Phyrn is involved in the rash of thefts and framing people, which is causing battles. They are mad because of Bruis being captured and Xena given asylum too. They lost today, but they will come back next battle day with a vengeance. We need to be prepared."

"What are we preparing for?" Catria asked. "All they can do is decide to attack in the arena."

Rhys shook his head. "You are innocent, Catria. Bloodshed is not allowed outside the arena, but that will not stop them. They will just try not to get caught."